were asked whether these eight characteristics of working for Vale identified by Vieira were applicable to their situations. While the situations in each country are completely different, the overwhelming response to the survey was that Vieira's characterisation of working for Vale resonated profoundly in the other countries (Marshall 2012).

Mining companies competing within the neoliberal world order

Vale's rapid ascent to become a major global player in the mining sector occurred within a consolidated neoliberal world order. While Vale wrapped itself in the Brazilian flag and adopted the elevated language of the Global Compact, its operations at home and abroad were characterised by relentless implementation of production targets, even at the cost of security in its mines and safety along its export corridors. It showed a callous and widespread disregard for human rights and assumed only as much responsibility for the damages its operations inflicted on workers, communities and the environment as the law – or adverse publicity – forced it to do.

Vale showed no hesitation in benefiting from just the asymmetries of power alluded to by Joseph Stiglitz when he awarded the 'worst company in the world' prize to Vale. This is evident in relation to the indigenous, ex-slave or traditional farming and fishing villages in northern Brazil, already negatively impacted by the original 890-kilometre transport corridor linking the Carajás iron mines to the São Luis port and now facing massive expansion of that line (Faustino and Furtado 2013). It is equally true in relation to the 1300 families in traditional peasant farming communities in Mozambique who lost their lands and livelihoods because they were in the way of Vale's new coal mines in Mozambique (Mosca and Selemane 2011).

The neoliberal world order in which Vale has emerged as a major player creates daunting challenges for Vale workers and communities and, indeed, for all those caught in its wake as the company forges ahead to realise its dreams of global dominance. Whether working for Vale in long-established mining cultures like Canada or Australia or working for Vale in its new mega-projects in Mozambique or Guinea or Indonesia, workers are faced with a company that epitomises all the worst of the current trends in global mining.

What are these contemporary practices of big mining companies based in the old imperial centres that Vale has so readily espoused? An analysis of these current trends was the main theme of an International Mining Conference organised by the United Steelworkers union in Toronto in June 2012. Andrew Vickers, Mining and Energy Sector Secretary of the Australian union CFMEU,